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## AUTONOMOUS VEHICLES

# Travis Kalanick reportedly wants to buy a Waymo rival, and Uber might help him

By [Rosie Bradbury](#)

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Former Uber CEO Travis Kalanick | *Elijah Nouvelage/Getty Images*

Travis Kalanick is in talks with [Uber](#) to fund his acquisition of the US business of Chinese self-driving car company [Pony.ai](#), The New York Times reported Thursday.

The deal—eight years after Uber ousted Kalanick as CEO—is the latest indication that the ridehailing company is worried about self-driving cars eating into its market share. It’s been offering [Waymo](#) rides in Austin through its app since March. These grew to about 20% of Uber’s ridehailing trips in the city by the end of that month, according to consumer data tracker Yipit Data.

Pony.ai, whose stock price jumped 13% following the report, is still only testing its autonomous vehicles in cities in California and Arizona. The company is preparing to sell or spin off its US subsidiary by March. The Commerce Department passed a rule this year barring the use of autonomous driving software controlled by a Chinese entity.

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Waymo, a subsidiary of [Alphabet](#), has “first mover advantage” in American self-driving ridehailing and received a mega-round of \$5.6 billion in venture funding led by Alphabet in October. It has plans to expand its fleet to cities including New York and Washington, DC.

If the deal goes through, Kalanick would run Pony and remain in his current role as CEO of startup [CloudKitchens](#), according to The New York Times report.

When Kalanick was still CEO of Uber, he attempted to break into the self-driving car sector by poaching researchers from Carnegie Mellon University and acquiring the new startup of the former lead of Alphabet’s self-driving car unit. The latter set off a lengthy legal dispute with the search giant, whose settlement included Waymo receiving a small stake in Uber.

Kalanick, Pony.ai, and Uber did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

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About [Rosie Bradbury](#)

Rosie Bradbury is a senior reporter covering startups and venture capital for PitchBook News. Based in New York, she previously reported for the Bureau of Investigative Journalism, Business Insider and Wired. Rosie studied history and politics at the University of Cambridge.

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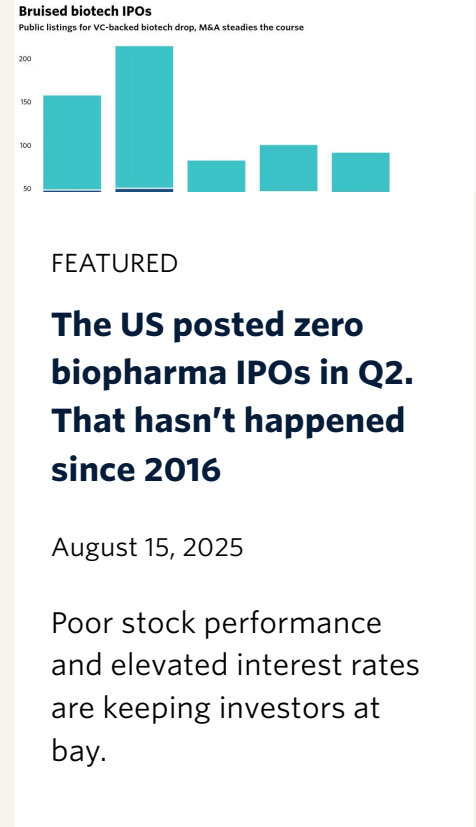


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